

# Euphemism and Moral Distance Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 20-25 min

|            |                        |      |                              |
|------------|------------------------|------|------------------------------|
| Category   | Knowledge and Language | Time | 20-25 min                    |
| Difficulty | Easy                   | ID   | euphemism-and-moral-distance |

Big idea: Language can hide responsibility.

## Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

## Concrete Stimulus Packet

|                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus A</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 1: Paired terms such as 'collateral damage' and 'civilian deaths'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust. | Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.         |
| <b>Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus B</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 2: Workplace or political language that softens responsibility. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.    | Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.                                 |
| <b>Euphemism and Moral Distance Reveal / Twist</b> | Student-facing stimulus 3: A moral-distance scale showing how language changes judgement. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.  | Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Language can hide responsibility. |

## Actual Lesson Questions

| # | Question for students                                                                         |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | After inspecting Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim? |
| 2 | Which exact detail from Euphemism and Moral Distance Stimulus A did you use as evidence?      |
| 3 | What did you infer beyond the evidence?                                                       |
| 4 | How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?                                      |
| 5 | What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?                              |
| 6 | Can language make unethical actions seem acceptable?                                          |

## Ready-to-Use Examples

- Paired terms such as 'collateral damage' and 'civilian deaths'.
- Workplace or political language that softens responsibility.
- A moral-distance scale showing how language changes judgement.

## Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

## Activity Steps

1. Students rank each phrase pair from most direct to most distancing.
2. They identify who benefits from the softer phrase.
3. Groups rewrite each phrase in clearer language.
4. Discuss when tact becomes distortion.

## Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

| What I noticed | What I inferred | Evidence | Confidence |
|----------------|-----------------|----------|------------|
|                |                 |          |            |
|                |                 |          |            |
|                |                 |          |            |

## TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can language make unethical actions seem acceptable?
- Is precise language an ethical responsibility?
- How do institutions control knowledge through vocabulary?

## Knowledge Questions

- Can language make unethical actions seem acceptable?
- Is precise language an ethical responsibility?
- How do institutions control knowledge through vocabulary?

## Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with paired terms such as 'collateral damage' and 'civilian deaths'. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

## Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...